

LATIN LITERATURE OUTLINE

EARLY LATIN LITERATURE

Livius Andronicus

(Lucius Livius Andronicus)

ca. 284 – ca. 204 BC (b. Tarentum)

“**The Father of Latin Literature**,” He came to Rome as a slave in 272 BC when the Romans captured Tarentum following the war with Pyrrhus. He wrote the ***Odussia***, a translation of Homer’s *Odyssey* that is the earliest extant Latin literature in order to show the basics of Greek literature to the children of his master Livius Salinator. It was used as Roman school text for more than two centuries. It was written in an early Italian meter called **Saturnian verse**. He used the term “Camena” to translate Homer’s “Muse.”

He also wrote the first Roman comedy and Roman tragedy, for the Ludi Romani in 240 BC, becoming the first to produce plays in Rome. In addition to tragedy, comedy and epic poetry, he also wrote lyric poetry. He composed a *parthenion* in honor of Juno in 207 BC. Cicero regarded his work as antiquated and not worth reading.

Gnaeus Naevius

c. 270 BC – 201 BC (b. Capua; d. Utica)

A dramatist and the first native Italian to write Latin literature. Pioneered “**fabulae praetextae**,” tragedies written on Roman historical material. He was the first to write an epic on an Italian subject (*Bellum Punicum*). He was imprisoned and died in exile because of his feud with the powerful Metelli family, reflected by the arrogant remark that “it’s fate that makes the Metelli consuls at Rome” (“Fato Metelli fiunt Romae consules”). He died in exile 201 BC in Utica.

- ***Bellum Punicum*** – epic poem about First Punic War; written in Saturnian verse.
 - Arranged into seven books by the grammarian Lampadio
 - Narrates the story of Aeneas who arrives in Latium from Troy
- ***Clastidium*** – example of fabula praetexta (a new genre he introduced)
- ***Romulus*** – example of fabula praetexta

Plautus

(Titus Maccus/Maccius Plautus)

c. 254 or 255 – c. 184 BC (b. Sarsina)

A comic playwright, who preceded Terence. Broadway play “A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum” is based on a compilation of his works. Varro supposedly said that if the muses had spoken Latin, they would have spoken the type of Latin that appeared in the works of Plautus.

Noteworthy Plays of Plautus:

- ***Miles Gloriosus*** (“the Braggart Soldier”)
 - a clever slave manages to steal away from the boastful soldier Pyrgopolynices the girl loved by his young master
 - the longest of Plautus' plays
- ***Mostellaria*** (“the Haunted House”)
 - The slave Tranio convinces his master's father that his house is haunted
- ***Aulularia*** (“the Pot of Gold”)
 - Deals with the misfortunes of a miser named Euclio who tries to hide his fortune
- ***Pseudolus***
 - A clever slave tricks the pimp Ballio out of a girl his young master loves
- ***Menaechmi***
 - Deals with twins separated at birth
 - Primary model for Shakespeare's *Comedy of Errors*
- ***Amphitruo***
 - Deals with the confusion over Heracles' birth
 - Only play on a mythological subject
- ***Captivi*** (“The Captives”)
 - deals with the efforts of a well-to-do father to ransom his son who has been taken prisoner of war
 - mentions imprisonment of Naevius
 - has no female characters
- ***Curculio*** (“the Weevil”)
 - Deals with a parasite of a young man who is in love with a courtesan
 - the shortest of Plautus' surviving plays

Ennius

(Quintus Ennius)

239 – 169 BC (b. Rudiae in Calabria)

Wrote ***Annales***, an 18-book epic poem on Roman history. He adapted dactylic hexameter from Greek poetry into Latin, which made the transmission of Greek literature into Latin much easier, and made dactylic hexameter the official meter of Latin epic poetry (instead of Saturnian verse). A chief patron of Ennius was Cato the Elder, who originally brought Ennius to Rome, which was ironic because Cato the Elder scorned all things Greek. He was said to have three hearts (“tria corda”) because he spoke Latin, Greek and Oscan.

He was the first Latin writer to compose satire, and the last poet to write satire in a meter other than dactylic hexameter (Lucilius made dactylic hexameter the standard meter of satire). Ennius' nephew was the tragedian Pacuvius.

Pacuvius

(Marcus Pacuvius)

220 – c. 130 BC (b. Brundisium)

A tragedian, who was the nephew of Ennius. Cicero considered him the “**greatest of Latin tragic poets.**”

- ***Dulorestes*** (“*Orestes the Slave*”) – depicts Orestes driven mad by the Furies
- ***Niptra*** (“*The Bath*”) – depicts Ulysses' death at hands of Telegonus

Cato the Elder

(Marcus Porcius Cato)

234 – 149 BC

The “Father of Latin prose,” he was the first Roman historian to write his work in Latin. He helped Q. Ennius come to Rome. He was censor in 184 BC. His personality was noted as old-fashioned and puritanical.

- **Origines** – history of Rome (only fragments survive); 7 books
 - Began the work with a line of hexameter
 - First Roman history in Latin prose
- **De Agri Cultura** (aka **De Re Rustica**) – treatise on farming
 - The earliest Latin prose work to come down to us in its entirety

Terence

(Publius Terentius Afer)

c. 195 or 185 – 159 BC (b. Carthage)

A comic playwright who followed Plautus. Like Plautus, employed “new comedy.” He was born in Carthage and came to Rome as a slave. He made his theatrical debut in 166 BC. Scipio Aemilianus was probably his literary patron. All his plays are set in Athens. Ambivius Turpio acted in all his plays.

Plays of Terence:

- **Andria** (“Woman of Andros”)
 - Terence’s earliest work
 - In prologue, he defends **contaminatio**, which is the combination of elements multiple Greek plays into one Latin play
- **Adelphi** (“The Brothers”)
 - Comedy about twins, one born in country, one in city
- **Phormio**
- **Eunuchus**
 - Biggest commercial success
- **Hecyra** (“Mother in Law”)
 - produced successfully after two failed attempts
 - The audience preferred a show of tightrope walkers during the first and second attempts
- **Heauton Timorumenos** (“The Self-Tormentor”)
 - Clinia about to be separated from his wife, remarks “*homo sum, humani nil a me alienum puto*”
 -

Lucilius

(Gaius Lucilius)

c. 180 – 102 BC (b. Suessa Arunca)

Established hexameter as the meter of Roman satire. He was the first Latin writer to focus exclusively on satire (Ennius had been the first to write it). His collection of satires were called **Sermones** (or **Ludus ac Sermones**), in 30 books. Horace called him his “Light/Lantern,” for the influence he had on the later satirist. In particular, Horace modeled on Lucilius his satires on a trip to Brundisium and his chance encounter with a bore. Lucilius was the great-uncle of Pompey the Great.

LATE REPUBLICAN LITERATURE

Cicero

(Marcus Tullius Cicero)

January 3, 106 - December 7, 43 BC (b. Arpinum; d. Formiae)

One of Rome's greatest orators. His chief rival in his early legal career was Hortensius Hortalus. He was the first husband of Terentia. His children were Marcus and Tullia. He addressed the majority of his letters to T. Pomponius Atticus.

Noteworthy Speeches:

- ***Pro (Sexto) Roscio Amerino*** (80 BC)
 - Cicero's first speech in a criminal case
 - Attacked Chrysogonus, an influential freedman of Sulla
- ***Pro Archia (Poeta)*** (62 BC) – Cicero's famous encomium to literature; he defended the Greek poet Archias' claim to Roman citizenship; Archias was from Antioch, and his citizenship was disputed by Cicero's political enemies
- ***Pro Caelio*** (56 BC)– Cicero's defense of a Caelius, who was accused by Clodia of poisoning her husband Q. Metellus Celer; Caelius had been involved romantically with Clodia (Catullus' Lesbia), who Cicero paints as a harlot
- ***Pro Lege Manilia*** (66 BC)
 - Supported Pompey's attempt to gain command against Mithridates
 - Also called ***De imperio Gnaei Pompeii***
- ***Philippics***
 - Attacked Mark Antony
 - Modeled on speeches of Demosthenes
- ***In Verrem***
 - Prosecuted Verres for extortion as governor of Sicily
 - Posed Cicero against rival Hortensius, the greatest orator of his day
- ***In Catilinam*** – 4 orations against Catiline;
 - First begins: "quo usque tandem abutere Catilina, patientia nostra" (how long will you abuse our patience, Catiline?)

Noteworthy Essays and Philosophical Works:

- ***Cato Maior*** or ***De Senectute*** (on Old Age) – a dialogue among Cato the Elder, Laelius and Scipio Aemilianus; modeled on Plato's *The Republic*
- ***Laelius*** or ***De Amicitia*** (on Friendship)
- ***De Republica*** –
 - Preserved in part by a commentary of Macrobius and partly only on palimpsests
 - Contains ***Somnium Scipionis (The Dream of Scipio)*** as its conclusion
 - Scipio here is Scipio Aemilianus, and he is transmitting Roman and family tradition to the younger generation
 - *De Republica*'s use of dialogue was inspired by Plato
- ***De Natura Deorum*** (45 BC) - Lucilius Balbus the Stoic, Aurelius Cotta the Academic, and Velleius the Epicurean debate different schools of philosophy; addressed Cicero's view of the gods

Varro

(Marcus Terentius Varro)

106 – 27 BC (b. Reate)

Rome's greatest scholar, who wrote over 500 books. Dated the founding of Rome to 753 BC.

- ***De Lingua Latina*** – exhaustive treatise on Latin language in 25 books
- ***De Re Rustica*** (aka ***Rerum Rusticarum Libri Tres***)
 - 3rd book covers raising barnyard animals, bees and fish

Caesar

(Gaius Julius Caesar)

July 12, 100 – March 15, 44 BC (b. Rome, d. Rome)

- ***(Commentarii) De Bello Gallico*** – Caesar wrote first 7 books; Aulus Hirtius (one of his lieutenants in Gaul) wrote number 8.
 - Originally called “*Gai Iulii Caesaris Commentarii Rerum Gestarum*”
- ***(Commentarii) De Bello Civili***
 - Written to dispel notion that he was a revolutionary like Catiline
 - Caesar repeatedly claims that his political enemies had forced on him a war he never wanted
- ***De Analogia*** – lost work on Latin grammar; Cicero said that Caesar purified the Latin language

Cornelius Nepos

(Cornelius Nepos)

c. 100 – 25 BC

- ***De Viris Illustribus*** (About Famous Men), his only extant work, and is first surviving Latin biographical work.
 - Biographies included such figures as Cicero and Cato the Elder
 - Dedicated to Atticus, included in biographies

Lucretius

(Titus Lucretius Carus)

98 – c. 55 BC

According to Jerome, he was driven to madness by a love potion, which reportedly killed him. Vergil wrote of him (in the *Georgics*) “*Felix qui potuit rerum cognoscere causas*” (blessed is he who understands the nature of things”).

- ***De Rerum Natura*** (6 Books)
 - Dedicated to C. Memmius in opening lines
 - Invokes Venus, as goddess of creation
 - Opening line “*Aeneadam genetrix, hominum divumque voluptas*”
 - Espouses/explains philosophy of Epicurus (i.e. Epicureanism)
 - It was revised and published by Cicero (according to Jerome)
 - Incorporates atomic theories of Leucippus and Democritus, which was the scientific basis for Epicureanism

Sallust

(Gaius Sallustius Crispus)

86 – 35 BC (b. Amiternum)

He suffered the humiliation of being expelled from the Senate in 50 BC due to a scandal involving the wife of Annius Milo. He served in Africa with Julius Caesar, who was his political protector and sponsor. Sallust became the first governor of the new province of Africa Nova. He claimed in *Bellum Catilinae* that he abandoned politics in disgust at the wholesale corruption. He was the 2nd husband of Terentia. Quintilian considered him the Roman equivalent of Thucydides, because he followed traditions set forth by the early Greek historian. Both of his historical monographs featured the theme of the struggle of the Populares.

- ***Bellum Catilinae***
 - a historical monograph about conspiracy of Catiline
- ***Bellum Jugurthinum***
 - historical monograph about the Jugurthine war
 - He had Punic documents translated for the latter while he was governor in Africa Nova
- ***Historiae***
 - written in 5 books about the period between 78 and 67 BC

Catullus

(Gaius Valerius Catullus)

c. 84 – c. 54 BC (b. Verona)

Called his works “*nugae*” (trifles) and his work a “*lepidum novum libellum*” (a polished new little book). His tendency to wallow in emotion caused many Romans to be uncomfortable with his work and dismiss his lyric poetry as valueless. He often lampooned Caesar (“nil nimium studio ,,, tibi velle placere, nec scire utrum sis albus an ater homo”). Scholars described young poets like Catullus as **neoterics**, because they reject traditional forms and poetic content and search for new styles.

Wrote poems to Lesbia, who was really Clodia. Clodia’s husband was Quintus Caecilius Metellus Celer. She had also been a lover of Caelius, defended by Cicero in *Pro Caelio*.

Served on the staff of Memmius, governor of Bithynia, where he visited his brother’s grave in 57 BC (“et in perpetuum frater, ave atque vale”).

- Began one of his poems, “Cenabis bene, mi fabulle.”
- Addresses one to her lover’s pet, a sparrow
- Wrote “lugete o Veneres Cupidinesque”
- In Catullus 63, he used Galliambic meter (even though it was an epic) to express the frenzy of the cult of Cybele in a poem about Cybele and Attis, which was an epyllion (and the usual meter for an epyllion was hexameter)
- Poem 64 is an epyllion on marriage of Peleus and Thetis
- Poem 68 is a translation of Lock of Berenice

AUGUSTAN & GOLDEN AGE LITERATURE

Augustus

63 BC – 14 AD

He wrote a biography dedicated to Maecenas and Agrippa (possibly referring to *res gestae*).

- ***Res Gestae*** – Latin text found on Monumentum Ancyranum found at site of modern Ankara;

Vergil

(Publius Vergilius Maro)

10/15/70 – 9/21/19 BC (b: Andes, in Mantua [in Cisalpine Gaul], d: Brundisium)

Shy, unassuming personality.

- ***Eclogues* (aka *Bucolica*/ *Bucolics*)**
 - The adult Vergil's first literary work
 - 10-poem collection of pastoral poetry, shepherds as main characters
 - Modeled on *Idylls* of Theocritus, a pastoral poet
 - Written in dactylic hexameter
 - 4th Eclogue (Messianic Eclogue) begins “Sicelides Musae, paulo maiora canamus” and predicts Golden Age that will begin with birth of wonder-child
- ***Georgics***
 - 4-book collection of poems concerning agriculture, farming
 - Book 4 was about bee-keeping, and contained myth of Aristaeus and the bees
- ***Aeneid***
 - 12-book, epic poem, dactylic hexameter
 - “Written to imitate Homer and to praise Augustus”
 - First six books modeled on *Odyssey*; 2nd six books modeled on *Iliad*
 - Book 1
 - begins: “Arma virumque cano” (I sing of arms and the man)
 - contains line: “dux femina facti” (a woman, i.e. Dido, was the leader of the deed)
 - Book 2 contains story of Trojan horse
 - Book 6
 - Aeneas’ trip to underworld, led by Sibyl
 - contains allusion to death of Marcellus, Augustus’ nephew; Octavia (Marcellus’ mom) fainted when Vergil read this passage to imperial family
 - ends with the death of Turnus
 - Plotius Tucca and Varius Rufus were Vergil’s literary executors, whom he asked to burn the unfinished *Aeneid* if he died; August forced them to do otherwise

Epitaph: “Mantua me genuit; Calabri rapuere; Tenet nunc Parthenope. Cecini pascua, rura, duces.”

Translation: “Mantua gave birth to me; Calabria snatched me up (i.e. I died in Brundisium); Naples holds me now (i.e. my tomb is there). I sang of pastures (i.e. *Eclogues*), farms (i.e. *Georgics*), and rulers (i.e. *Aeneid*).” The epitaph is in Dactylic Hexameter.

Horace

(Quintus Horatius Flaccus)

65 – 8 BC

b. Venusia in Apulia

He came from humble origins but was grateful for his father who, though a poor freedman, gave his son the care and education ordinarily received only by the aristocracy. His mean schoolmaster was Orbilius. He served as a tribunos militum under Brutus and fought on the side of Brutus and Cassius at Philippi, leading to the confiscation of his estate. He loved his Sabine farm (ager Sabinus), which was given to him by Augustus through the help of Maecenas. Called Lucilius his “lantern” for his influence in satire.

- ***Epodes*** (aka ***Iambi***)
 - Horace said that he borrowed meters and inspiration from the Greek poet Archilochus
- ***Odes*** (aka ***Carmina***)
 - collection of lyric poems
 - 3 books, published in 23 BC; 4th book published in 13BC, at Augustus' request
 - Addressed to Maecenas
 - Modelled on the Greek lyric poet Alcaeus
- ***Sermones*** (aka ***Saturae***, ***Satires***)
- ***Carmen Saeculare*** – written at request of Augustus for celebration of Ludi Saeculares (centennial games), 17 BC
 - Chorus of 27 boys and 27 girls

Ovid

(Publius Ovidius Naso)

43 BC – 17 AD (b. Sulmo in Abruzzi, d. Tomi)

Allegedly, when he tried to write prose, it came out as poetry. Banished to Tomi(s) on the Black Sea by Augustus, allegedly for “Carmen et error,” likely referring to Augustus displeasure over content of *Ars Amatoria*. During his exile, he wrote a poem in the Getic language which was spoken at Tomis.

- ***Metamorphoses***, i.e. transformations
 - 15 books, ~250 myths
 - Dactylic hexameter
 - Ends with the transformation (by Venus) of Julius Caesar into comet
- ***Heroides*** (aka ***Epsitulae Heroidum***)
 - Contains fictional letters from mythological heroines to their lovers.
 - Written in Elegiac Couplet
- ***Ars Amatoria*** (“*the Art of Love*”)
 - 3 books; how to win the girl, how to win the guy (i.e. 3rd book written for women)
- ***Fasti*** –
 - A Roman calendar of feast dates ,holidays, religious rituals and their origins
 - Written in elegiac couplets
 - Only 6 books (not the intended 12), because interrupted by Ovid’s exile
- ***Tristia*** – lamentations that Ovid began writing it upon his exile; Describes last night in Rome, voyage to Tomis, and exile
- ***Amores***
 - love elegies; includes poems addressed to Corinna and her parrot

Livy

(Titus Livius)

c. 59 BC to 12 or 17 AD (b. Patavium)

His principal work was the “massive” *Ab Urbe Condita*, which was divided in 142 books, covering seven centuries of Roman history (up to 9 BC and the death of Drusus). Its publication was unusual because it was published in installments. Supposedly, Augustus jokingly called him “Pompeian (Pompeianus)” because of his work’s nostalgic republicanism. He reportedly intended to end his work with the death of Augustus, but instead concluded it with the death of Drusus (brother of Tiberius). His style specifically rejected the historical monograph-style of Sallust.

He was criticized by Asinius Pollio for “Patavinitas,” referring to his provincial language or slang derived from his hometown of Patavium (Padua). Claudius was tutored by Livy, and encouraged by him to pursue his studies of history.

The summaries, or short synopses, written to condense Livy's voluminous history were called *Periochae*. Only books 136 and 137 do not have *Periochae*.

Tibullus

(Albius Tibullus)

Bet. 55 and 48 – 19 BC

Wrote love elegies. Tibullus addressed his poems to Delia, whose real name was Plania (according to Apuleius). His corpus incorporated poems of Sulpicia, who wrote to Cerinthus. Sulpicia’s uncle was Messala (Valerius Messala Corvinus), the patron of Tibullus. Tibullus’ work also incorporates the poems of Lygdamus.

Was called “*tersus atque elegans*” by Quintilian, because his literary style was simple and luminous, free and refined. His fondness for using depictions of the rural world as the substitute for an ideal mythological world sharply distinguished him from other elegiac poets of the 1st-century AD.

Propertius

(Sextus Propertius)

c. 50 BC – after 16 AD (b. Assisi)

Wrote love elegies addressed to Cynthia. Therefore he called his first book *Cynthia Monobiblos*. Cynthia’s real name was Hostia, according to Apuleius. His patron was Maecenas. Propertius called himself the Roman Callimachus (a famous Greek poet). His elegies contained stories of Vertumnus, the dedication of the Temple of Palatine Apollo, and the legend of Hercules and Cacus

Cornelius Gallus

(C. Cornelius Gallus)

An elegiac poet who wrote a 4-book collection of elegies called *Amores*. The subject of his elegies was Lycoris (Volumnia, a mime actress whose stage name was Cytheris). Lycoris was also romantically involved with Mark Antony before Gallus. He served as the first governor of Egypt, until he was removed for setting up statues of himself.

SILVER AGE LITERATURE

Seneca the Younger

(Lucius Annaeus Seneca)

4 BC – 65 AD (b. Cordoba)

Stoic writer who was a tutor of Nero. He had been exiled to Corsica for eight years (from 41 to 49 AD) for alleged adultery with Caligula's sister, Julia Livilla. Seneca was forced to commit suicide by Nero after being implicated in the **Pisonian conspiracy**.

- ***Apocolocyntosis***, "Pumpkinification"
 - a fictional depiction of the death of the Emperor Claudius
 - Example of Menippean Satire, mixing prose and poetry
- ***Epistulae Morales***
 - 124 letters to Lucilius, a friend of Seneca the Younger
- ***Octavia***
 - tragedy on the reign of Nero, Agrippina's ghost foretells of Nero's doom.
 - the only extant example of *fabula praetexta*

Lucan

(Marcus Annaeus Lucanus)

Silver-age epic poet. Lucan studied stoicism under Cornutus (Lucius Annaeus Cornutus) in Rome. Wrote epic poem ***Bellum Civile*** (others gave it the name ***Pharsalia***), about the civil war between Caesar and Pompey. It was a sort of "Anti-Aeneid." Nero prohibited him from publishing his poetry, and later forced Lucan to commit suicide in 65 AD for involvement in the **Pisonian conspiracy**. He is said to have recited his own poetry while committing suicide at the age of 25.

Juvenal

(Decimus Iunius Iuvenalis)

b. Aquinum

Writer of satires which display rancor towards society and hidden resentment at not belonging to it. He proclaimed that widespread moral corruption compelled him to write the satires. Domitian exiled Juvenal to Egypt. Sixteen of his satires survive. Famous for line "*quis custodiet ipsos custodies*." Considered the last classical Latin poet of any importance and the greatest satirist.

Noteworthy Satires:

- **Satire 1**: declares his disgust at the widespread moral corruption which compels him to be a satiric poet
- **Satire 3**: claims that life in Rome is dangerous for honest men; describes why his old friend Umbricius had to abandon Rome
- **Satire 6**: the longest satire; famous tirade against immorality and vices of women; cites empress Messalina as the ultimate example of an immoral woman; says that a chaste woman is a "*rara avis*"
- **Satire 15**: episode of cannibalism in Egypt provoked by religious fanaticism

Tacitus

(Publius Cornelius Tacitus)

His political career began in the Flavian dynasty, with offices under all three Flavian emperors, and concluded with a proconsulship in Asia under the reign of Trajan. He also served as consul under Nerva. He delivered the funeral oration of Verginius Rufus in 97 AD.

- ***Annales***:
 - Tacitus called the *Annales* “ab excessu divi Augusti,” because they begin with the death of Augustus
 - Proclaimed that the opening crime of Tiberius' reign was the murder of Agrippa Postumus
- ***Historiae***
 - Covers year of the four emperors (69) and Flavian emperors (69-96) (i.e. Galba to Domitian)
 - *Historiae* were written before the *Annales*; they were often later published as a combined edition
- ***Agricola*** (aka ***De Vitae Julii Agricolae***) –
 - Tacitus' first historical work published in 98 A.D.
 - A short biography of his father-in-law
 - Depicts Caledonian chieftain Calgacus giving speech to his men before battle of Mons Graupius
- ***Germania*** (aka ***De Origine et Situ Germanorum***) (98 AD) –
 - Contains various descriptions of tribes along the Rhine, consisting of a study of the people, geography and customs of Germania
 - A large part of it was probably based on Pliny the Elder's *Bella Germaniae*
 - Published in 98 AD (same year as *Agricola*)
- ***(Dialogus) de Oratoribus*** – discussion on the decline of Latin oratory, and the impotence of orators under imperial rule
 - Tacitus' first work

Persius

(Aulus Persius Flaccus)

Silver age satirist heavily influenced by stoicism. Wrote 6 stoic Satires. Said his muse was his “venter” (i.e. his belly). Persius' fifth satire eulogizes Cornutus, who was his teacher and cherished friend.

Martial

(Marcus Valerius Martialis)

A renowned writer of Epigrams.

- ***Liber Spectaculorum*** (aka ***Liber de Spectaculis***) – celebrated the opening of the Colosseum
- ***Epigrammata*** (Epigrams) – 12 Books of Epigrams

Petronius

(Gaius/Titus Petronius Arbiter)

“Arbiter Elegantie” of Nero's court. Wrote the *Satyricon*, the first Latin novel which contains the famous Cena Trimalchionis scene (banquet of Trimalchio)

Quintilian

(Marcus Fabius Quintilianus)

Summoned to Rome in 68 by Galba and began career as teacher of rhetoric. Wrote the *Institutio Oratoria* which discusses the training of an orator.

Suetonius

(C. Suetonius Tranquillus)

A renowned biographer. His father had been on the losing side at the Battle of Bedriacum in 69 AD. He received the *ius trium liberorum* from Trajan in 110 AD.

- *Lives of the Caesars (de vita Caesarum)*: covers 12 Caesars, beginning with Julius Caesar and ending with Domitian, and including many scandalous details of their lives
- *De Viris Illustribus* ("About Famous Men") – biographies of famous writers subdivided by genre

Pliny the Elder

(Gaius Plinius Secundus)

- *Historia Naturalis* (the Natural History) – a 37-Book Encyclopedia
- *Bella Germaniae* – historical work used as a source by Tacitus (for *Germania*)

Pliny the Younger

Nephew of Pliny the Elder, and studied under Quintilian. Trajan protected him and gave him the governorship of Bithynia. His letters to and from Trajan still survive. One of his letters to Tacitus contains details of the Vesuvius eruption, where his uncle died.

Apuleius

- *Metamorphoses*, also called *The Golden Ass*
 - The only Latin novel that has survived to us in its entirety in 11 books
 - The story of Cupid and Psyche figures prominently in books 4 through 6.
- *Apologia* (aka *De Magia*)
 - defense in trial for witchcraft (that he had bewitched a rich widow named Aemilia Pudentilla into marrying him);
- *Florida* – 23 oratorical passages

Statius

(Publius Papinius Statius)

c. 40-50 AD b. Naples

Silver age epic poet who flattered Domitian in many of his works. Considered a protégé of Domitian.

- *Thebaid* – an epic on the royal house of Thebes, confrontation of Eteocles and Polyneices
- *Achilleid* – an unfinished epic about Achilles
- *Silvae* – a miscellany of smaller poems with verses on various topics

LATER LITERATURE

Lactantius

(Lucius Caelius/Caecilius Firmianus Lactantius)

The “Christian Cicero.” Christian author who dedicated *Institutio Divinae*, a work justifying Christianity to educated pagans, to emperor Constantine. His style was greatly influenced by Cicero. He was a pupil of Arnobius, and the tutor of Constantine’s children, including Crispus.

Jerome

(St. Jerome, Sophronius Eusebius Hieronymus)

c. 347-420 AD b. Stridon, Dalmatia

- *Vulgate (Biblia Vulgata)* – Latin translation of Bible for common man, translated from Hebrew Old Testament and Greek New Testament
- *De Viris Illustribus* (About famous men) – covering lives of 135 Christian authors, from St. Peter to Jerome himself
- *Chronica* – historical treatise from Constantine to death of Valens

Eutropius

A historian who participated with Ammianus Marcellinus in Julian's expedition of 363 AD against the Persians.

- *Breviarium ab Urbe Condita*
 - Compendium of Roman history in 10 books
 - Covers period from Romulus to Jovian (364 AD)
 - Written at request of emperor Valens, because he found himself unable to read the detailed works of Livy and other historians

St. Augustine

He was the bishop of Hippo, in Africa. He converted first to Manichaeism, then to Christianity.

- *De Civitate Dei* (“on/about the City of God”) – discusses errors of paganism and the existence of an earthly city and a heavenly city; it was written to restore the confidence of his fellow Christians after the sack of Rome in 410 AD
- *Confessions* – **autobiography** recounting of his spiritual struggles, in which he reached levels of psychological analysis never reached before in professing his distress over sin

Ammianus Marcellinus

c. 325/330 AD – after 391 AD (b. Antioch)

Historian who continued work of Tacitus to his own day. Wrote a 31-Book *Res Gestae (A Fine Corneli Taciti)* covering the period from Nerva to Valens. Participated with Eutropius in Julian's expedition of 363 AD against the Persians. Called himself “*quando miles quondam et graecus*” (“a soldier and a Greek”).